

Alachua County Animal Welfare Advisory Committee Minutes

August 9th, 2023

Members Present

Brandi Ormerod
Meredith Montgomery
Chelsea Bower
Perry Koon
Stacy Hudak

Members Absent

Amy Tate
Melissa Moomaw

Staff Present

Julie Johnson
Sarah Gilley
Faye Gould
Chelsea Meyer
Skye Barkley

Call to Order

The meeting was called to order at 1:02pm

Approval of the Agenda and Meeting Minutes

Motion could not be made to approve the agenda and minutes from previous meeting as quorum was not met. Final Agenda and minutes will be approved at the next meeting.

Public Comments

Floor was opened for public comment at 1:03pm. The following questions were raised:

- ACAR Volunteer Chris Deutsch wanted to bring attention to dogs getting time outside of kennels, stated she knew heat was a factor but wanted to ensure enrichment distribution was not a substitute for dogs getting one-on-one time with staff and dogs with behavioral problems get more time out. Requested ACAR investigates other shelters and organizations also in hot climates to see what they do in times of extreme heat. Also raised the question why ACAR had so many puppies currently in the shelter compared to previous years when they went to rescue quickly.
- ACAR Volunteer Melissa Wokasch wanted to call the committee's attention to the heat in the kennels, specifically the heat on the back row. She requested that ACAR looks into misting devices to keep the shelter cooler, that shades go up in the back yards as only yards 1-3 have adequate shades, requested later volunteer hours in the summer months to allow for cooler evening shifts. Mentioned kennels on the edges have water pooling in from the covers during rain. Also mentioned having an easier way to document volunteer medical concerns for the animals to ensure they are being followed up on.

- Public citizen Dottie Dreyer asked about anonymous reporting, specifically if public citizens could gain access to know who in the community called in to report, stated she wanted to thank citizens for reporting cruelty. County Attorney Diana Johnson responded that public citizens can make public record requests.
- Public citizen Kathleen Rupert asked if there was a minimum number of trips/ reports that need to be made for cruelty before ACAR takes action with cases. Also asked about the funds for the new shelter building, Julie Johnson responded that the money is still in our budget for use, and asked what the policy was for reporting found animals. Chair Brandi Ormerod responded that there is more information on the ACAR website with that information.

Introduction of New Staff and Committee Members

- 1:15pm – Introduction of new committee member, LEO Perry Koon. Perry introduced himself as a sheriff's deputy with the Alachua County Sheriff's Office and handles cases related to livestock.
- Introduction of new Shelter Supervisor, Chelsea Meyer. Chelsea has a background working in non-profit rescue and veterinary practices.
- Introduction of new Foster Coordinator, Skye Barkley. Skye was a previous Kennel Technician at ACAR promoted to the Foster Coordinator role.
- A new Animal Behavior and Rescue Coordinator begins on August 21st.
- Onboarded 4 new Kennel Technicians, an Investigator, and an Officer was promoted to Investigator. Just completed interviews for a new veterinarian from the University of Florida to begin at the shelter.

Old Business

- 1:25pm – Jessica Hurov, the Tourism Development Manager for Alachua County, stated the board requested that the Animal Welfare Advisory Committee look into the activities for the Agriculture and Equestrian Center to ensure practices are acceptable before implementing. The mounted shooting events were already removed. Quorum was not met at this time, determined the activities would be reviewed again during a meeting with quorum.
- Director Announcements: Heat Concerns - Director Julie Johnson made several announcements, began by addressing heat concerns. Stated heat was preventing regular playgroups, but staff is still distributing enrichment items, specifically frozen items, and taking dogs out when they can closely monitor for signs of heat distress, and there are plans in place to alleviate heat in kennels. New fans have been ordered, 2 new fans are on the back row with more coming. At the recent budget meeting, more items were approved – pet-friendly astroturf in the yards, shades to be erected over ever play yards, and splash pads. ACAR will look into misters and where they can be placed to minimize slip accidents. The new shades will be marine shades that will be more breathable to allow air in and out and improve air flow. Addressed a dog that had recently passed at the shelter – a full necropsy was completed with no definitive results, but high anxiety levels and heat could have attributed to the dog's demise. Chelsea Bower also

responded that the Humane Society of North Central Florida has paused play groups due to the heat. Brandi Ormerod suggested signs with information on signs of heat distress, Chelsea Bower suggested retraining staff and constant reminders about heat concerns.

Director Announcements: Intakes and Outcomes – Julie Johnson addressed public comment about increased number of puppies in-house. Stated rescue partners are also full or have cases of parvovirus and unable to accept larger puppies at this time, but pleas are being sent. Reported intake numbers are up from this time last year, primarily due to cases being completed and animals confiscated in a timelier manner. Brandi Ormerod asked if animals being fostered by finders is factored into the intake number, Julie responded yes. Brandi Ormerod and Chelsea Bower requested that the numbers be broken down further for the next meeting if possible. Julie Johnson also shared that adoption percentage is up, rescue transfer percentage was about the same. Chelsea Bower stated HSNCFCL would be willing to collaborate with ACAR on microchip and/or sterilization initiatives. Meredith Montgomery (entered at 1:43pm) and Stacy Hudak requested more social media posts regarding lost/found animals, microchips to assist with return-to-owner initiatives. Sarah Gilley confirmed ACAR is looking into a return-to-owner volunteer task force. Julie Johnson stated calls to dispatch have almost doubled since last year, and certain cases require animals are housed longer. Perry Koon asked if humane euthanasia is being considered when ACAR is over-capacity, Julie Johnson stated multiple members of leadership meet often to discuss outcomes, and humane euthanasia may be considered if it is in the best interest of the animal and public safety. Sarah Gilley stated average length-of-stay has decreased to 30 days for dogs, and initiatives to push foster homes and rescue partnerships helps ACAR identify behavior cases faster to discuss potential outcomes at these meetings. Sarah Gilley stated feedback from volunteers and their reporting has also been extremely beneficial. Chelsea Bower responded about volunteers, addressed the earlier public comment about medical reporting stating that HSNCFCL has a medical clipboard for volunteers. ACAR will look into this as an option for volunteers.

Agriculture and Equestrian Center

Meredith Montgomery entered at 1:43pm, quorum was now met to allow for voting of activities at the Agriculture and Equestrian Center. Meredith Montgomery brought articles related to several activities and had concerns regarding several activities, petting zoos, bull riding, steer roping, sorting and any activities using calves. Meredith Montgomery and Stacy Hudak mentioned several items that would help make the petting zoos less of a zoonotic risk and more comfortable for the animals in the petting zoos, including hand wash stations, no food in the petting zoo areas, and having retreats with physical, visual, and auditory barriers for the animals to take breaks.